FORTIFYING HEALTH

₹95,957 crore
Total allocation for healthcare sector, up from last year's ₹**86,582 crore**

₹9,406 crore
Allocation for Ayushman Bharat health insurance scheme, up by 29 per cent from last year's portion of ₹**8,300 crore**

₹4,200 crore
Allocation for Ayushman Bharat Health Infrastructure Mission, a **40 per cent** increase from previous year

Attacking Cancer

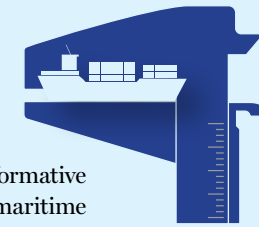
Budget 2025 has addressed one of the most prevalent diseases that can cripple one financially—cancer. The exemption of 36 life-saving drugs from basic customs duty, along with a concessional 5 per cent duty on six additional medicines, will make critical treatments more affordable for patients suffering from cancer and rare diseases. The inclusion of 37 additional medicines and 13 new patient assistance programmes will further ease patients' financial burden. The decision to establish daycare cancer centres in all district hospitals over the next three years marks a transformative step in making cancer care more accessible to all strata of society.

The Heal in India initiative aims to develop medical tourism. This will boost investment and create jobs in the sector

THE BENEFITS

According to the Indian Council of Medical Research, estimated new cancer cases in India were 1.4 million in 2022, and expected to increase by 12.8 per cent by 2025. The expenses are ruinous for many patients too. There are huge gaps in access to quality cancer care. This is why the budget's focus on reducing the financial strain of life-threatening diseases and improving access to care at a district level is laudable. The budget also promotes the 'Heal in India' initiative under which India will be developed as a healthcare destination through improved services and bigger private sector participation. The investment in medical infrastructure will boost the economy and create jobs. The budget has also provided for health insurance for gig and platform workers, thus addressing a critical gap in their well-being. ■

MARITIME MAKEOVER



The budget delivers a transformative push in the oft-neglected maritime sector with a Rs 25,000 crore Maritime Development Fund (MDF), ensuring long-term, low-cost financing for shipbuilding, port modernisation and inland waterways. With 49 per cent government funding and private sector participation, it is expected to attract Rs 1.5 lakh crore in investments by 2030. The revamped Shipbuilding Financial Assistance Policy provides 20-30 per cent subsidies for shipbuilding. Customs duty exemptions on raw materials for 10 years and the inclusion of large ships in Infrastructure Harmonised Master List ensure cost competitiveness. Shipbreaking credit notes (40 per cent of scrap value) encourage sustainable ship recycling and reinvestment.

Maritime Development Fund will boost domestic manufacturing and increase India's flagged fleet

₹ 25,000 CRORE
Maritime Development Fund with 49% govt contribution aims to unlock Rs 1.5 lakh crore investment in the shipping sector by 2030

₹6,100 crore
Allocated for upgrading and modernising shipyards

1.1 million
No. of jobs expected from maritime sector investments

THE BENEFITS

Aimed at reducing India's $75 billion annual ship-leasing expenditure, MDF will boost domestic manufacturing and increase India's flagged fleet. The country's current global shipbuilding market share is below 1 per cent, yet with MDF-backed incentives, industry growth could mirror the successes of China, South Korea and Japan, who dominate over 90 per cent of the sector. The introduction of tax sops for ship-leasing makes India a more attractive destination for global maritime investments. Moreover, the shipbreaking credit note system not only strengthens India's circular economy but also ensures that funds are reinvested into new ship production, fostering shipyard activity.

India's inland waterways sector receives a hefty boost with the tonnage tax extension, making river-based transport a cost-effective alternative to road and rail logistics. Also, the Rs 1,200 crore allocation for Shipbuilding Capability Development Centres and Rs 1,040 crore for ship design and training initiatives emphasise skill enhancement, ensuring a steady pipeline of qualified professionals. ■

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